

start syncing data to your training app, things can become incredibly clear.

For example, if you had a glass or two of wine or beer the night before a workout, your HRV may be much lower, and your workout may not feel as easy as it should have. Of course, you already knew that drinking the night before a workout isn't ideal, but actually seeing its effects in your app and health insights really hammers the message home.

A sports psychologist once gave a very helpful tip: never think of workouts as 'good' or 'bad'. A workout is simply information. Use it and learn from it. That's exactly how you should interpret your training data too.

Hard and easy days

We often fall into the trap of thinking faster equals better, and more equals more.

But fitness doesn't always come from trying harder or doing more. It comes from applying the right stimulus at the right time.

Distinct visual targets help you keep the easy days easy and ensure you're training at the correct threshold level. On the flip side, they help control pacing during hard workout sessions so you don't explode early, while also keeping you accountable when you start to feel sorry for yourself.

This is especially helpful for

beginners or when you're trying a new sport. For example, during injury rehabilitation and recovery, structured workouts within an app can help you learn to control your pacing. It also reduces the mental effort required during workouts and helps you execute sessions better when fatigue sets in through prompts and variability.

When the work pays off

It feels good to check in regularly and see yourself adding more and more structure to the scaffolding of your fitness parameters.

Your app does the same thing. Every time you complete a workout or check off an exercise, you're building that scaffolding a little taller. It's especially helpful when progress is colour-coded. Before a competition, you can scroll through the calendar and see months and months of 'green' workouts.

Many apps also include strength and sport-specific conditioning work, allowing you to see all your training in one place. It's incredibly empowering. The entire platform can be bespoke to the needs of each athlete and coach, offering a huge number of permutations and combinations.

These are just a few ways to visualise workout data, but there is no one-size-fits-all approach. Whether it's collecting points, tracking metrics, or using any other method, one thing is clear: visual evidence builds belief and trust.

So if you've ever struggled to trust the process, don't just tell yourself to trust it. Make it visible.

Because sometimes, what you see is what you get.

On the go: Fitness data can be a personal scorecard, but with a lot more information conveniently stored in the pocket instead (thanks to technology!). GETTY IMAGES

